

Call for Expressions of Interest	
<i>Date of Issue:</i>	September 2026
<i>Expected Completion Date:</i>	May 2027
<i>Project Title:</i>	Digital Persona 0.2
<i>Company:</i>	Blueskeye AI
Contact Details	
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Additional Info	
<i>Students must sign NDA:</i>	☐
<i>Project uses personal data:</i>	☒
<i>Custom hardware required:</i>	☐ If Applicable: Please provide details
<i>Relevant research areas (if applicable)¹:</i>	Computer vision; Avatars, Responsible AI; Agents; LLMs
Project Background Information	
This project, in partnership with Blueskeye, explores the concept of a digital persona: an interactive digital representation, or avatar (i.e., a form of 'digital twin') capable of engaging with others in a manner that is simulated yet authentic. This is exemplified by current advances in AI-powered chatbots, which are trained on a person's historical data, such as past conversations, to continue communicating with others in a way that mimics that individual's style, personality, and knowledge. The supervisors are keen to see genuine use of the facial expression recognition and voice emotion features, so that the digital representation can mimic social and emotional signals convincingly. In other words, the focus should be on evaluating how the digital persona communicates (i.e., prosody) and interacts, rather than solely on what it says (i.e., semantics). Further Research on Digital Cloning: The concept of <i>digital cloning</i> extends beyond mere simulation. It involves the ambitious technical goal of capturing, processing, and recreating a person's distinctive communication patterns, knowledge base, emotional tone, and decision-making heuristics to form a cohesive, interactive digital entity. This strand of the research will investigate specific algorithmic approaches (e.g., deep learning models and natural	

¹ An overview of different research areas in the school of computer science can be found [here](#).

language generation) needed to achieve a high-fidelity digital clone that functions credibly as an extension of the individual.

While personal digital twins are an emerging and exciting field, they carry profound implications. This research will address foundational questions about identity, memory, and the nature of consciousness as they relate to a simulated digital existence. As the technology advances, digital personas may offer a new way to preserve and extend an individual's digital legacy.

A closely related and instructive case is the emergence of 'deadbots' or AI systems that recreate deceased individuals for bereaved users to interact with. This growing industry raises many of the same tensions this project must navigate: the impossibility of obtaining ongoing consent from the person being modelled, the risk that a bot says or does things the original person would never have condoned, the potential for commercial services to exploit users' grief, and unresolved questions about who owns and controls a person's data and likeness once they can no longer speak for themselves. Emerging research also suggests such systems can complicate healthy grieving by fostering prolonged or pathological attachment rather than supporting acceptance. This project's digital persona is created with the living subject's active, revocable consent, rather than posthumously, but these debates remain directly relevant: they illustrate what can go wrong when consent, dignity, and data control are not built into a digital persona's design from the outset.

Responsible Research and Innovation (RRI) Framework:

To ensure the responsible development of digital cloning technologies, this project is committed to a robust RRI framework. Our work will proactively address:

- **Legal and Regulatory Frameworks:** Analysing and adhering to relevant laws concerning digital identity and data.
- **Privacy and Security:** Mitigating risks associated with data handling and secure access to the digital persona.
- **Unanticipated Consequences:** Identifying and preparing for potential ethical or social side effects.
- **Accountability and Data Curation:** Establishing clear guidelines for the ownership, maintenance, and ultimate disposition of the underlying data and the persona itself, including provisions for revoking consent and deleting data on request.
- **Stakeholder Perspectives:** Engaging with diverse groups to gather insights and concerns.
- **Consent and Ethical Approval:** Formal ethics approval will be sought before any data capture begins, and every individual whose likeness, voice, or data is used will give informed, revocable consent at each stage of the project.

Note: To ground the ethical and practical study of digital cloning in a concrete case, the student cohort will be invited to choose the lead academic investigator as the subject for the digital cloning process, with the investigator's explicit, revocable consent and appropriate ethics approval secured in advance. The cohort will then be responsible for both the technical

development and the ethical analysis involved in creating the lead investigator's digital persona for teaching or afterlife purposes.

Reading list:

- Jokinen, J. P. P., & Silvennoinen, J. (2020). The Appraisal Theory of Emotion in Human–Computer Interaction. In R. Rousi, J. Leikas, & P. Saariluoma (Eds.), *Emotions in Technology Design: From Experience to Ethics* (pp. 27-39). Springer International Publishing.
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-53483-7_3
- Öhman, C., & Floridi, L. (2018). An ethical framework for the digital afterlife industry. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 2(5), 318-320.
<https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-018-0335-2>
- Hollanek, T., & Nowaczyk-Basińska, K. (2024). Griefbots, deadbots, postmortem avatars: On responsible applications of generative AI in the digital afterlife industry. *Philosophy & Technology*, 37, Article 744.
<https://doi.org/10.1007/s13347-024-00744-w>
- Parmar, D., Olafsson, S., Utami, D., Murali, P., & Bickmore, T. (2022). Designing empathic virtual agents: manipulating animation, voice, rendering, and empathy to create persuasive agents. *Autonomous Agents and Multi-Agent Systems*, 36(1), 17.
<https://doi.org/10.1007/s10458-021-09539-1>
- Zimmerman, A., Janhonen, J., & Beer, E. (2023). Human/AI relationships: challenges, downsides, and impacts on human/humanrelationships. *AI and Ethics*. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s43681-023-00348-8>
- Edwards, L., & Harbina, E. (2013). Protecting post-mortem privacy: Reconsidering the privacy interests of the deceased in a digital world. *Cardozo Arts & Ent. LJ*, 32, 83.

Requirements	
<i>The group must provide:</i> A finalised interface design for the avatar applying and considering: Embodied Conversational Agent (Avatar) Capturing idiosyncratic facial behaviour in a generative model Generating idiosyncratic facial behaviour according to that model LLMs NLP; sentiment analysis; personality modelling Privacy policy and Terms and Conditions Ethical guidelines Data protection User Manual Consent protocols	
Skills	
<i>Highly desirable:</i> Knowledge of legal and ethical frameworks (privacy law, intellectual property law, consumer protection law). Familiarity with social constructivism, to reflect on the societal implications of cloning technology. AI and statistics.	<i>Desirable:</i> AI Ethics, RRI, Explainable AI, data privacy, responsible data governance, 3D character modelling, gaming.
Submission / Award information	
<i>Date of Submission:</i>	September 2026
<i>Date of Pitch:</i>	October 2026
<i>Notification of award:</i>	October 2026

For further information on this proposal, the team representative should in the first instance e-mail the lead contact stated above at the e-mail address provided.